

Asia Chart Alert

Global Markets Research

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Economics - Asia ex-Japan

Nomura's leading index of Asian exports

After having risen for six months in a row, NELI dipped slightly but is still near historical highs, which suggests Asia's exports remain on very solid footing.

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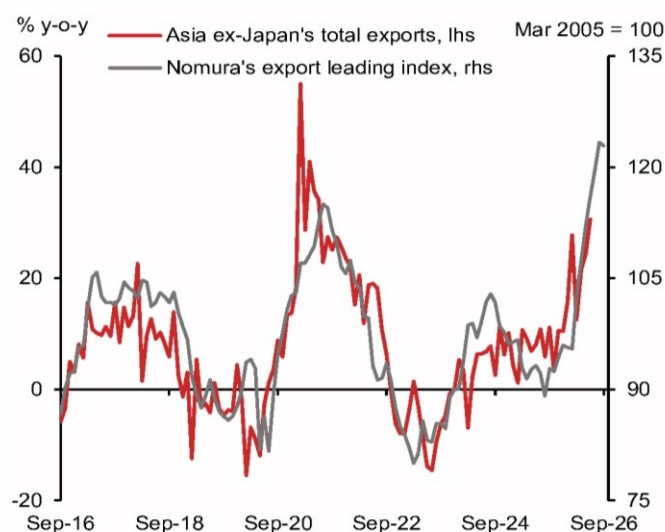
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Fig. 1: Nomura's leading index of Asian exports



- Nomura's leading index of Asia ex-Japan's aggregate exports, or NELI for short, comprises nine components and has a three-month lead time. NELI has correctly predicted past major turning points and is less distorted by base effects than official export data, making it a good momentum leading indicator of Asia's underlying export growth.
- After having risen for six months in a row, NELI dipped slightly to 122.9 in September, reflecting a modest pullback in a few tech-related indicators and China's imports. Nonetheless, NELI remains close to historic highs, which suggests this is likely a consolidation at elevated levels rather than the start of a downturn. Overall, NELI is signalling that Asia's export growth remains on solid footing.
- The principal driver of Asian exports remains the AI tech supercycle, which continues to display strong momentum, as global AI capex continues to expand, and *demand continues to outweigh supply* of memory and advanced logic chips. That said, we remain watchful of renewed supply-chain disruptions and *soft domestic demand in China*, which pose downside risks to Asia's otherwise robust export trajectory.

Note: Nomura's export leading index can be found on Bloomberg (see ticker: NMEIXLI). Asia ex-Japan's aggregate (nominal) exports include those of China, Hong Kong, India, Indonesia, South Korea, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore, Taiwan and Thailand. China's exports to Hong Kong are excluded due to outsized swings on some occasions that seem unrelated to trade activity. Nomura's export leading index is a weighted (inverse of mean-squared errors) sum of the following Z-score standardized variables: Shanghai Shipping Exchange Containerized Freight Index, China's imports, China's imports from Asia, global semiconductor sales, US manufacturing ISM, S&P EM manufacturing PMI, China RatingDog (formerly Caixin) manufacturing PMI, South Korea's semiconductor exports and Philadelphia Semiconductor index. (For more details on its construction, see *Re-calibrating our Asia export leading index*, 16 August 2022).

Source: IHS Markit, CEIC, Bloomberg and Nomura Global Economics.

Appendix A-1

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